PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 12 - Why Do We Wage War?

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- Next week, review + midterm. Ask questions early rather than later
- Today we move to one of the oldest questions in IR: **why do states and groups resort to violence?**
- Paradox: war is devastating and costly — so why does it happen?

Today's Schedule

- The Puzzle of War
- Why Peace Fails: Five Paths to War
- Norms, Conquest, and the International Order

The Puzzle of War

Opening Discussion

What do you think are the most common causes of war? And: if war is so costly, why does it happen at all?

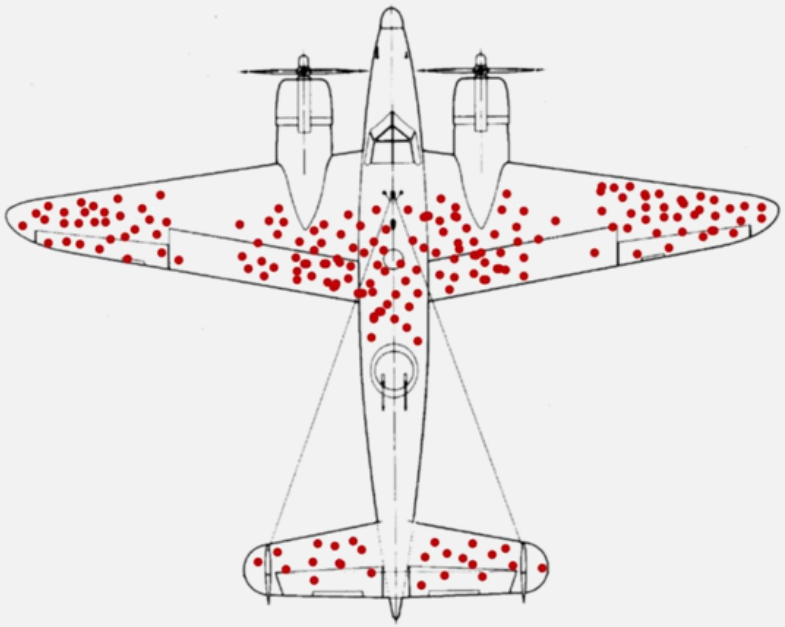
Most Common Assumptions Are Wrong

- Most powerful countries do **not** try to conquer their neighbors
- Almost all ethnic groups — even those with territorial disputes — **live in peace**
  - In Africa, roughly 1 in 2,000 ethnic-group dyads experienced some form of violence
- Almost all states with territorial disputes resolve them **without violence**
- Very few oppressed populations wage revolutions
- <u>If war is so rare, why do we hear so much about it?</u>

Selection Bias: The Wald Problem

Why do we get the causes of war wrong?

Selection bias causes us to focus on cases where things went wrong, not on when things went right.



War Is Almost Always Irrational

- War involves **deadweight losses** — destruction that benefits no one
- Both sides can estimate their odds of winning and the costs of fighting
- It is almost always better to **cut a deal** (Why?)
- *"There is no instance of a country having benefited from prolonged warfare"* — Sun Tzu

The Bargaining Logic: a Rationalist explanation

- Imagine two gangs fighting over territory worth **$100 in profit**
- Fighting costs **$20 in deadweight losses** (injury, destruction, legal risk)
- Each has roughly a **50% chance** of winning
    - Expected value of fighting = $40 each, with certainty of some losses
- If they **bargain instead**: they share the $100 profit **plus** the $20 they didn't destroy
- Rational actors should always find a **bargaining range** that beats going to war

So Why Does War Happen?

- If bargaining is always preferable, war is a **puzzle** — it requires a specific explanation
- Wars are **ex ante inefficient**: both sides could theoretically agree to a settlement that makes them better off
- Peace is the default; war requires something to **break** the logic of peace
- Can you think of a real-world case where bargaining clearly failed? What went wrong?

Why Peace Fails: Five Paths to War

When the Logic of Peace Breaks Down

- Peace is the norm; war is the exception that needs explaining
- There are five mechanisms that undermine the bargaining logic (according to Blattman)
- These apply across interstate wars, civil wars, and group conflicts (like gangs!)

1. Unchecked Interests

- War happens when the people who **decide** to fight do not bear the costs
- Leaders gain power, territory, glory, or domestic distraction — without paying with their own lives
- *"War is old men talking and young men dying"*
- The path to peace: **checks and balances** that force leaders to more directly bear the costs of war
- Can you think of contemporary examples where leaders bear few personal costs of the wars they start?

2. Intangible Incentives

- Groups may not care about material losses if they value **something beyond material gains**
- Religion: the promise of spiritual rewards that outweigh physical costs
  - *"Deus le Volt!"* — the rallying cry of the First Crusade
- Honor, glory, masculinity: *"Battle is the most magnificent competition in which a human being can indulge"* — George S. Patton
- Intangible incentives can create **indivisible issues**: things that seem impossible to negotiate over
- The path to peace: **changing norms and ideologies** that eliminate intangible incentives for violence

3. Uncertainty

- Groups cannot perfectly measure each other's strength — and they have **strong incentives to misrepresent**
  - Revealing true weakness invites exploitation
- Leaders bluff about their strength and resolve: *"We will chase the Americans to every corner at all times. No high tower of steel will protect them against the fire of truth"*
- Uncertainty makes bargains harder to strike — both sides may gamble on war
- The path to peace: **reducing uncertainty** through costly signals (military exercises, international inspections, credible demonstrations of resolve)

4. Commitment Problems

- Both sides would be better off cooperating today, but **know they would prefer to double-cross in the future**
- Often arises when both sides know the **balance of power will shift**
  - The rising party cannot credibly commit to not exploiting its future advantage
  - Think back to the Prisoner's Dilemma
- Example: civil war peace deals require rebel groups to disarm — but disarming makes them **permanently vulnerable** if the other side breaks its promises
- The path to peace: **security guarantees, third-party mediation**, and institutional assurances

5. Misperceptions

- Psychological factors cause actors to **systematically overestimate** their own strength
- Napoleon before invading Russia: *"This will be glorious for the French arms… the peace we shall conclude will terminate the fatal influence which Russia has exercised in Europe"*
- Groups are also bad at **modeling the other side's perspective** — we assume others see the world as we do
- If they harm us, they must be uniquely evil — this **demonization closes off negotiation**
- Which of these five reasons do you think is most dangerous? Which is hardest to fix?

Norms, Conquest, and the International Order

War as an Instrument of Policy

- A classical insight: war is not chaos — it is a **continuation of policy by other means**
- States fight to achieve **political objectives**, not because of some natural urge to violence
- But war is always shaped by three forces in tension: **passion** (the people), **chance** (the fog of war), and **rational calculation** (the government)
- In practice, plans rarely survive contact with the enemy — commanders operate with **incomplete information**

The Norm Against Conquest

- For most of modern history, the norm against territorial conquest became so deeply internalized that violating it was “inconceivable”
- Why did the norm develop?
  - Statehood became **increasingly valuable** — recognized states get international protections, trade access, diplomacy
  - Trade made conquest **less economically attractive** — you don’t need to own territory to profit from it
  - International law increasingly treated **aggression as a crime**

When Norms Erode

- Russia's invasion and annexation of Ukrainian territory is historically **unprecedented** in the modern era (is it?)
- If conquest succeeds without serious consequences, other states will **update their beliefs** about the permissibility of territorial expansion
- *"If the prohibition against territorial conquest ends up in the graveyard of norms, then history will turn backward, and the world will revisit the brutal era of violent state death"*
- How does this argument about norms relate to the five causes of war? Which of the five does norm erosion primarily address?

Trade and the Incentives for Peace

- Economic interdependence can reduce the likelihood of war: fighting your trading partner destroys mutual gains
- Trade creates **shared economic interests** and domestic constituencies that lobby against conflict
- But limits exist: high economic integration did not prevent WWI in 1914
- Do you find this argument convincing? What conditions would need to hold for trade to reliably prevent war?

Connecting the Frameworks: a Summary

- War as a rational instrument of policy — but passion and chance complicate it
- Bargaining should prevent war — so war requires a specific failure of the bargaining logic
- Five mechanisms break that logic: unchecked interests, intangible incentives, uncertainty, commitment problems, misperceptions
- Norms shape the perceived costs and legitimacy of war
- Economic structures shape the incentives for peace

For Next Wednesday: Homework

Homework: The US/Israel & Iran Conflict

On Wednesday we will spend the last part of class discussing **recent US and Israeli military action against Iran**

Before Wednesday, please:

1. **Research the conflict** — what happened, when, and why (news sources, Wikipedia, government statements)
2. **Read about the historical relationship** between Iran, Israel, and the United States
3. Come ready to discuss: **what states say vs. what they actually mean**

Research Questions to Guide You

Think through these questions as you read:

- What were the **stated justifications** for the action? What do you think the real strategic goals were?
- Which of the **five causes of war** best explains this conflict? Is it one cause or a combination?
- How do **norms** apply — is territorial conquest involved? What norms are at stake?
- What does **Iran say**? What do regional actors (Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Russia, China) say?
- What does this mean for the **future of the international order**?

Questions?